

INTRODUCTION TO HEALTH



Introduction to Health

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Introduction to Health

In this section, readers will learn about the nature of health, health education, health promotion and related concepts. This will help to understand the social, psychological and physical components of health.

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Thumbnail: Health is a critical aspect of human life. (CC BY-SA 2.0 Generic; [Tulane Public Relations](#)).

References

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Centers for Disease Control

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1.1: Narrow Perspectives of Health

People with a narrow perspective consider health as the absence of disease or disability or biological dysfunction. According to this view (or model), to call someone unhealthy or sick means there should be evidence of a particular illness. Social, emotional and psychological factors are not believed to cause unhealthy conditions. This model is narrow and limits the definition of health to the physical and physiological capabilities that are necessary to perform routine tasks.

According to this definition, the individual is healthy if all the body parts, cells, tissues and organ systems are functioning well and there is no apparent dysfunction of the body. Using this model people view the human body in the same terms as a computer, or mechanical device, when something is wrong you take it to experts who maintain it. Physicians, unlike behavioral experts, often focus on treatment and clinical interventions with medication rather than educational interventions to bring about behavior change.

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1.2: Broader Perspectives of Health

The most widely used of the broader definitions of health is that within the constitution of the World Health Organization (WHO), which defines health as: A state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being, and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity. This classic definition is important, as it identifies the vital components of health.

Well-being includes the presence of positive emotions and moods (e.g., contentment, happiness), the absence of negative emotions (e.g., depression, anxiety), satisfaction with life, fulfillment and positive functioning. In simple terms, well-being can be described as judging life positively and feeling good. Well-being is associated with numerous health-, job-, family-, and economically related benefits. For example, higher levels of well-being are associated with decreased risk of disease, illness, and injury; better immune functioning; speedier recovery; and increased longevity. Individuals with high levels of well-being are more productive at work and are more likely to contribute to their communities.

Many practitioners have expanded their focus to include wellness at the positive end of the health continuum. Wellness is being in good physical and mental health. Because mental health and physical health are linked, problems in one area can impact the other. At the same time, improving your physical health can also benefit your mental health, and vice versa. It is important to make healthy choices for both your physical and mental well-being. Remember that wellness is not just the absence of illness or stress. One can still strive for wellness even if he/she is experiencing these challenges in life.

To more fully understand the meaning of health, it is important to understand each of its individual components.

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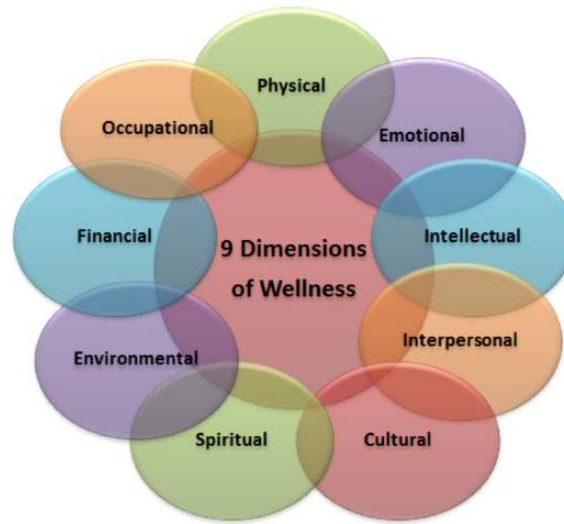
1.3: Dimensions of Wellness

What is Wellness?

Wellness is being in good physical and mental health. Because mental health and physical health are linked, problems in one area can impact the other. At the same time, improving your physical health can also benefit your mental health, and vice versa. It is important to make healthy choices for both your physical and mental well-being.

Remember that wellness is not just the absence of illness or stress. You can still strive for wellness even if you are experiencing these challenges in your life.

What are the Nine Dimensions of Wellness?



Learning about the Nine Dimensions of Wellness can help you choose how to make wellness a part of your everyday life. Wellness strategies are practical ways to start developing healthy habits that can have a positive impact on your physical and mental health.

The Nine Dimensions of Wellness are:

1. **Emotional:** Coping effectively with life and expressing emotions in an appropriate manner.
2. **Environmental:** Occupying pleasant, healthy, and safe environments that support well-being; positively impacting the quality of our surroundings (including protecting and preserving nature).
3. **Financial:** Achieving satisfaction with current and future financial situations; handling finances wisely.
4. **Intellectual:** Recognizing creative abilities and finding ways to expand knowledge and skills; being open-minded.
5. **Occupational:** Personal fulfillment and enrichment from one's work and/or responsibilities.
6. **Physical:** Recognizing the need for physical activity, healthy foods, and adequate sleep; avoiding unhealthy habits.
7. **Social:** Developing a sense of connection, belonging, and sustained support system; having positive relationships.
8. **Spiritual:** Having a sense of purpose and meaning in life; establishing peace, harmony, and balance in our lives.
9. ***Cultural:** The way you interact with others who are different than you; understanding and celebrating our differences.
(*recently added).

Learn more about the Eight Dimensions of Wellness (does not include Cultural wellness) by watching the video below:



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tDzQdRvLAfM>

Your Own Views on Health and Wellness

Reflect on the following questions:

- What does health mean to you?
- How important is health to you?
- What are some of your healthy habits?
- Which dimensions of wellness do you need to work on the most?

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1.4: Behavior Change and Goal Setting

Transtheoretical Model (Stages of Change)

The transtheoretical model of behavior change, developed by Prochaska and DiClemente, assesses an individual's readiness to implement a healthier behavior and provides insight into the decision making process that leads to action. For many people, changing or modifying a behavior that is unhealthy or potentially harmful can be quite challenging. Here are the stages that lead to behavior change:

- Precontemplation (Not Ready) – You are not intending to take action in the foreseeable future, and can be unaware that your behavior is problematic
- Contemplation (Getting Ready) – You are beginning to recognize that your behavior is problematic, and start to look at the pros and cons of your continued actions
- Preparation (Ready) – You are intending to take action in the immediate future, and may begin taking small steps toward behavior change
- Action – You are making actual changes to your problem behavior by incorporating healthy choices/behaviors into your life
- Maintenance – You have been able to sustain action for at least six months and are working to prevent relapse into previous unhealthy behaviors

Stage 1: Precontemplation (not ready)

People at this stage do not intend to start the healthy behavior in the near future (within 6 months), and may be unaware of the need to change. People here learn more about healthy behavior: they are encouraged to think about the pros of changing their behavior and to feel emotions about the effects of their negative behavior on others.

Precontemplators typically underestimate the pros of changing, overestimate the cons, and often are not aware of making such mistakes.

One of the most effective steps that others can help with at this stage is to encourage them to become more mindful of their decision-making and more conscious of the multiple benefits of changing an unhealthy behavior.

Stage 2: Contemplation (getting ready)

At this stage, participants are intending to start the healthy behavior within the next 6 months. While they are usually now more aware of the pros of changing, their cons are about equal to their Pros. This ambivalence about changing can cause them to keep putting off taking action. People here learn about the kind of person they could be if they changed their behavior and learn more from people who behave in healthy ways.

Others can influence and help effectively at this stage by encouraging them to work at reducing the cons of changing their behavior.

Stage 3: Preparation (ready)

People at this stage are ready to start taking action within the next 30 days. They take small steps that they believe can help them make the healthy behavior a part of their lives. For example, they tell their friends and family that they want to change their behavior.

People in this stage should be encouraged to seek support from friends they trust, tell people about their plan to change the way they act, and think about how they would feel if they behaved in a healthier way. Their number one concern is: when they act, will they fail? They learn that the better prepared they are, the more likely they are to keep progressing.

Stage 4: Action (current action)

People at this stage have changed their behavior within the last 6 months and need to work hard to keep moving ahead. These participants need to learn how to strengthen their commitments to change and to fight urges to slip back. People in this stage progress by being taught techniques for keeping up their commitments such as substituting activities related to the unhealthy behavior with positive ones, rewarding themselves for taking steps toward changing, and avoiding people and situations that tempt them to behave in unhealthy ways.

Stage 5: Maintenance (monitoring)

People at this stage changed their behavior more than 6 months ago. It is important for people in this stage to be aware of situations that may tempt them to slip back into doing the unhealthy behavior—particularly stressful situations. It is recommended that people

in this stage seek support from and talk with people whom they trust, spend time with people who behave in healthy ways, and remember to engage in healthy activities to cope with stress instead of relying on unhealthy behavior.

Relapse (recycling):

Relapse in the TTM specifically applies to individuals who successfully quit smoking or using drugs or alcohol, only to resume these unhealthy behaviors. Individuals who attempt to quit highly addictive behaviors such as drug, alcohol, and tobacco use are at particularly high risk of a relapse. Achieving a long-term behavior change often requires ongoing support from family members, a health coach, a physician, or another motivational source. Supportive literature and other resources can also be helpful to avoid a relapse from happening.

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1.5: SMART Goal Setting



Figure 1.5.1 SMART Acronym

Have you ever said to yourself that you need to “eat healthier” or “exercise more” to improve your overall health? How well did that work for you? In most cases, probably not very well. That’s because these statements are too vague and do not give us any direction for what truly needs to be done to achieve such goals. To have a better chance at being successful, try using the SMART acronym for setting your goals (S= Specific, M= Measurable, A=Attainable, R= Realistic, T= Time-oriented):

Specific – Create a goal that has a focused and clear path for what you actually need to do.

Examples:

- I will drink 8 ounces of water 3 times per day
- I will walk briskly for 30 minutes, 5 times per week
- I will reduce my soda intake to no more than 2 cans of soda per week

Do you see how that is more helpful than just saying you will eat healthier or exercise more? It gives you direction.

Measurable – This enables you to track your progress, and ties in with the “specific” component. The above examples all have actual numbers associated with the behavior change that let you know whether or not it has been met.

Attainable – Make sure that your goal is within your capabilities and not too far out of reach. For example, if you have not been physically active for a number of years, it would be highly unlikely that you would be able to achieve a goal of running a marathon within the next month.

Realistic – Try to ensure that your goal is something you will be able to continue doing and incorporate as part of your regular routine/lifestyle. For example, if you made a goal to kayak 2 times each week, but don’t have the financial resources to purchase or rent the equipment, no way to transport it, or are not close enough to a body of water in which to partake in kayaking, then this is not going to be feasible.

Time-oriented – Give yourself a target date or deadline in which the goal needs to be met. This will keep you on track and motivated to reach the goal, while also evaluating your progress.

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1.6: The Six Dimensions of Health

1. Physical

Body size and functioning; recognizing the need for physical activity, healthy foods, and adequate sleep; avoiding unhealthy habits

2. Social

Developing a sense of connection, belonging, and sustained support system; having positive relationships

3. Intellectual

Recognizing creative abilities and finding ways to expand knowledge and skills; being open-minded

4. Emotional

Coping effectively with life and expressing emotions in an appropriate manner

5. Spiritual

Having a sense of purpose and meaning in life; establishing peace, harmony, and balance in our lives

6. Environmental

Occupying pleasant, healthy, and safe environments that support wellbeing; positively impacting the quality of our surroundings (including protecting and preserving nature)

Learning about the Six Dimensions of Health can help a person choose how to make wellness a part of everyday life. Wellness strategies are practical ways to start developing healthy habits that can have a positive impact on physical and mental health.

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